

Due to the fact that this is a very personal project, there haven't been many other attempts to improve the outdoor portion of our school. However, based on research into similar schools in the area, adding a garden or welcoming space has, for the most part, been positive and appreciated.

One example of this is the DCB Garden Project. DC Bilingual is another school in DC, similar to DC International School. DC Bilingual School is a relevant stakeholder since they went through a very similar process to the one we are. As a school, they face similar challenges that we will. Also, DC Bilingual had its own garden, which underwent a process similar to the one we will have at DCI. Therefore, it is important to learn about the pros and cons that they faced and see how they can help us as we continue through the phases of making the garden.

To learn more about their project, we did some research and we contacted the garden team at DCI.

Example of email to DC Bilingual:

Subject: Garden Space Project Overview

"To whoever it may concern at DCB,
I am Gonzalo Baires Lazo, a student who attended DCB! I am doing an engineering project with peers in DCI, my current school, and we are planting a small garden. I have CC'd my engineering peers, who are Laine Harter, Jodha Borse, and Roberto (Didier) Saravia. I have also added my engineering teacher, Stephen Muskett.

We want your help on how you all planted the garden. We would love to have in-depth details, the people involved in the project, some strengths and some areas of growth, and some ideas on what you all could have done before finishing the project. If possible, our team could attend the garden in person to get more inspiration for our project.

Thank you for your time,
Gonzalo, Laine, Didier, Jodha"

Additionally, we sent messages to other non-profits in the DC area to learn about their process. However, neither organization replied to our messages. One of the organizations that we contacted is DC Natives. DC Natives is a relevant stakeholder because they are volunteers who provide advice to DC residents who are trying to plant native pollinator gardens. So, even though they usually help people trying to make gardens at home, we could also ask if they can assist us in finding native plants for the garden at DCI.

Example of message to DC Natives:

Subject: Garden Space Project Advice for Students at DC International School

“Good morning,

To whom it may concern at DC Natives, my name is Jodha Borse, and I'm a student at DC International School. My peers, Laine, Gonzalo, and Roberto (Didier), who are CC'd as well as our engineering teacher, Mr. Stephen Muskett, and I are doing an engineering project where we are working with the school to help plant a small garden in a green area in front. For the garden, we were wondering if we'd be able to meet with you and hopefully get some advice on how to proceed with the project. We would love it if you could give us ideas on native plants to use or notes for the management of the garden.

Thank you for your assistance!
Jodha, Laine, Didier, and Gonzalo”

However, there was more than just plants involved in this project. Additionally, we have to research methods to make the concrete slabs. To do this, we found different videos online, instructional materials, and articles on the best methods to make strong, long-lasting concrete.

More specifically, we tried to find the best ratios of water to concrete powder. This was to avoid making as many mistakes while creating the first couple of slabs, since the materials we had were limited.

Finally, we also looked through garden group projects done by past students at DCI. From this, we reviewed what went well in their past projects. For example, we learned about how another group paced their project out and how they actually sectioned the project out. Also, another project reached out to the University of Maryland, which is helpful to know in case we might need similar help with our project.

Lastly, the information about other garden projects done at DCI allowed our garden group to more easily determine a budget to send to the school, based on the previous budgets given to garden projects.